

Barnsley FC Fan Advisory Board — Meeting Minutes

Date: Tuesday 8 September 2026

Format: Video call

Chair: Steve Brain

Attendees

Present:

- Steve Brain — Chair, representing season ticket holders
- Jon Flatman — Chief Executive Officer, Barnsley FC
- John Bird — Head of Ticketing and Fan Engagement, Barnsley FC
- Phil Hall — representing diversity and community
- Martin Wilson — representing disabled supporters
- Paul Gallagher — representing the Supporters Trust
- Dominic Wood — representing club sponsors and hospitality
- Peter Harrison — representing supporters living away
- Robin Harris — representing youth and children
- Claire Calton — representing women and girls (joined partway through the meeting)

Apologies:

- Alan Bloore — representing the Supporters Trust

Absent without apologies: None recorded.

Minutes of Previous Meeting

The Chair opened by noting that the August meeting's minutes had still not been published, and that the FAB had received criticism from supporters over the delay. Jon Flatman explained that on first reading the draft minutes contained a significant number of errors requiring correction; he had been through them that afternoon and returned them to John Bird, who confirmed he would finalise and publish them as his first job the following morning.

Paul Gallagher suggested part of the difficulty stemmed from the previous meeting's hybrid format (some attendees in a meeting room, others external), which affects the accuracy of automated transcription when Microsoft Teams cannot reliably distinguish speakers. This meeting, held entirely as a video call with all attendees external, was expected to produce a cleaner transcript.

It was agreed that, going forward, a note will be added to the bottom of minutes stating the date they were approved and the date they were published (for example: approved 8 September 2026, published 9 September 2026), so supporters understand where any delay has occurred and why.

No further comments were raised on the minutes process.

Agenda Items

1. Transfer Window — Recognition

Steve noted that Dominic Wood had proposed an additional agenda item recognising the club's work during the summer transfer window. The Chair passed on the group's thanks on behalf of supporters. Jon Flatman thanked the group and said he would pass the message on to all those involved.

2. Female Sanitary Products

The Chair noted that Claire Calton, who had raised this topic previously, was not yet present, but the item was addressed in her absence. Jon Flatman confirmed that the club has agreed in principle to resume stocking sanitary products in the ladies' toilets, as was previously done. The remaining work is to confirm the arrangements for supply and restocking with the maintenance team, who are already stretched, to ensure the products are used for their intended purpose. Jon Flatman said he believed any previous issues could be resolved and that the club is committed to returning to that position.

Outcome: Agreed in principle; club to finalise supply and maintenance arrangements. (See also Claire Calton's follow-up under Any Other Business.)

Update: Product will be in place for the Leicester City Fixture

3. Scoreboard / Video Screen

Jon Flatman raised this as a follow-up from the previous meeting, asking whether a new scoreboard is a priority for the Supporters Trust and the fan base.

Paul Gallagher said the topic had been briefly discussed with the Supporters Trust, where some members raised concerns about the optics of asking supporters to help fund equipment while the club spends significant sums on players, though he personally had no objection to the principle. No consensus had yet been reached; he agreed to take the question back to the Trust and circulate suggestions to the group within a few days.

Going round the group: Dominic Wood cited a recent away trip to Doncaster, where the scoreboard included instant replay facility, and felt this would benefit supporters and the club. Paul Gallagher noted this has been one of the most frequently requested improvements raised with the club by fans over many years. Martin Wilson said a scoreboard was, in his view, more important than a fan zone. Phil Hall said he personally has no strong need for a scoreboard beyond showing the score and the time, though acknowledged this was a personal view. Peter Harrison agreed with Dominic Wood that the Doncaster scoreboard, including replay capability, would be a positive addition.

John Bird and Jon Flatman both agreed a bigger, better screen would be a valuable addition to the Oakwell match-day experience and could also be used to display images of fans. John Bird noted that replay functionality is a separate capability requiring additional equipment and an operator, and suggested the screen itself should come first, with other functionality added afterwards.

On cost, John Bird confirmed the total quoted cost for the screen under consideration is £55,000, covering a screen the full width of the current screen and adjacent advertising boards, at double the current height. Paul Gallagher asked whether this included the video mixing equipment needed for replays; John Bird and Jon Flatman confirmed this is separate, off-the-shelf software rather than part of the hardware cost.

Dominic Wood asked whether increased advertising and sponsorship revenue from a larger screen could offset costs, and whether the club might commit a percentage of funding once a fundraising target is reached. Jon Flatman explained that advertisers will not commit funding for digital assets the club does not yet have, but that a bigger screen would increase the club's available digital advertising assets, to which

some value could be attributed. He confirmed the club would need to contribute funding itself, alongside any third-party or fan contributions.

Peter Harrison, who has professional experience with AV suppliers, offered to make enquiries with his own industry contacts for comparison. Jon Flatman welcomed this, noting the club would need suppliers with direct manufacturing capability rather than distributors, given the technical requirements around structural mounting (stadium maintenance) and network integration (IT).

Jon Flatman described the scoreboard as a potential "signature project" for the FAB, given it would benefit every supporter in the ground.

Actions:

- Paul Gallagher to raise the scoreboard with the Supporters Trust and circulate suggestions to the group.
- Peter Harrison to approach AV industry contacts for comparative quotes.
- The FAB to consider options for fundraising or crowdfunding support between meetings.

4. Academy Support Funding

Jon Flatman raised this as a related funding topic. Jon Flatman explained the club is looking to increase resources put into the Academy, noting the rising cost of running it (not in player wages, but in associated costs) and suggesting the FAB or Supporters Trust might identify a specific project to support.

He shared the following figures on Academy performance and investment (drawn from the club's Academy reports):

- Last season, 11% of first-team minutes were played by Academy graduates, against a League One average of 7%.
- On average, 3.28 Academy-developed players featured in every matchday squad last season.
- This season to date, 33.9% of first-team minutes have come from Academy players; four players have played over 400 minutes each; roughly three-quarters of the matchday bench has come from the Academy in every game; and nine different Academy players have featured.
- Individual minutes to date: Rogan Ravenhill and Arley Kay have played every available minute; Luke Alker has played 434 minutes; Jonathan Bland has played 426 minutes.
- Last year the club spent £2.319 million running the Academy (Category 2, covering all age groups up to under-21s), offset by £804,000 of grant aid funding, meaning the club itself contributed around £1.51 million.
- Across Category 2 Academies nationally, the highest spend was £4.662 million, the average was £2.7 million, and the lowest was £1.6 million — placing Barnsley's spend broadly in line with the average.
- Two Academy players were sold this season (fees undisclosed); Jon Flatman noted the proceeds do not come close to offsetting the club's annual £1.51 million contribution.

Paul Gallagher asked whether the £1.51 million investment represents value for money. Jon Flatman said the club uses a model valuing wages, potential transfer value, community impact, squad depth and player pathways, which is reviewed regularly, and that the club would not continue the investment if it were not satisfied it was the right decision.

Discussion turned to specific areas that could be supported by fan or third-party funding, including Academy transport, kit (currently self-funded by families to around age 16, when players join full-time), and nutrition. Dominic Wood suggested that Academy support could become the FAB's focus for fundraising, potentially in place of, or alongside, the scoreboard, and floated the idea of an auction of a matchday shirt to help fund kit for a specific Academy age group, drawing a comparison to schemes such as sponsoring a player. Steve asked whether Jon Flatman could put together a short list of five or six specific Academy funding opportunities at varying cost levels for the group to consider; Jon Flatman agreed to do so if there is interest.

Jon Flatman noted more broadly that the club faces constant competing demands on limited resources (scoreboard, pitch, fan zone, Academy, and more) and it is for the FAB, as a group, to decide which one or two priorities it wants to support.

Actions:

- Jon Flatman to produce a shortlist of five or six specific Academy funding opportunities, with indicative costs, for the group to consider.
- Paul Gallagher raised whether this and the scoreboard discussion warranted a separate, dedicated meeting; Steve agreed this should be arranged outside the regular FAB meeting.

5. The Ozone / Redfern's Bar

Paul Gallagher asked about plans for the Ozone, noting it was previously used to generate fundraising for the Academy via volunteer-run bar nights. Jon Flatman confirmed the club has plans for the space. He explained the primary challenge is not match-day usage but making the space a usable asset that can generate revenue across the wider week (24/7/365), rather than solely on match days. Discussions on this were held recently and the club hopes to announce plans in due course.

Outcome: No further update available at this time; announcement expected in due course.

6. Floodlights and Ground Lighting

Steve introduced this as two related topics: new floodlights, and reports of dark areas around the ground, particularly on leaving after evening games.

Peter Harrison raised that leaving the West Stand after last Wednesday's game, the area outside was very dark, with no apparent lighting, and that lighting was also out in the West Stand uncovered toilets, despite light fittings being present. He noted he had raised this with John Bird the previous Friday.

Jon Flatman explained these are two separate issues. First, pitch lighting: the club has installed new floodlights, which reduce the light pollution associated with the old lights (the reason they were replaced) and meet the higher lux standards required at Championship level, in case of promotion. Second, general ground lighting: the area is currently affected by a "perfect storm" — street lighting on Grove Street is temporarily out due to nearby housing works, which previously provided incidental overspill lighting to the West Stand area. The club is aware of this and is installing additional lighting around the West Stand and East Stand of the ground at a cost of approximately £10,000.

Paul Gallagher asked whether pitch lighting meets required luminance standards. Jon Flatman confirmed that lighting supplier Abacus has installed the system, that lux level tests are supplied to the EFL broken down by four-metre-square sections of the pitch, and that broadcasters set minimum lighting standards; failure to meet them can result in broadcast revenue being clawed back.

On the timeline for removing the old floodlight towers, Jon Flatman explained the towers also carry telecommunications equipment, extensive cabling and security cameras, making removal more complex than it might appear. His hope is for the towers to be down by summer 2027, though this depends on relocating that infrastructure elsewhere.

Dominic Wood asked whether a post-goal light show was possible; Jon Flatman said this is not viable, as light shows require advance notice so that supporters sensitive to flashing lights can move to the concourse, but a pre-match light show is possible in principle, though he noted some clubs' light shows have not been well received by supporters.

Dominic Wood asked whether the floodlights were funded through the Council's capital expenditure budget; Jon Flatman confirmed this was the case, alongside other stadium works funded from the same pot (see below).

Steve asked whether some of this information could be shared with the wider fan base. Jon Flatman said the council is understandably cautious given it is taxpayers' money, but agreed to raise with them the possibility of producing a summary document covering the activity funded and its impact.

On the wider capital works funded from the same grant, Jon Flatman confirmed that following had also been delivered: a new fire alarm system across all stands, offices and hospitality areas; refurbishment of the ticket office and club offices; a full CAD survey of the stadium above and below ground (mapping pipework, drainage and similar infrastructure, not previously documented); replacement of fire doors; and bringing forward planned replacement of ageing infrastructure such as boilers and electrical wiring. He noted the CapEx grant, originally around £2 million, buys less now than when it was awarded, due to rising construction costs, and that local suppliers were used throughout the works.

Steve noted this kind of detail is valuable for supporters to understand the financial and operational challenges the club faces, even where they are not always visible. Jon Flatman confirmed the day-to-day operational cost of maintaining the stadium is roughly £500,000 a year.

Actions:

- Club to complete installation of approximately £10,000 of additional lighting around the West Stand and East Stand.
- Jon Flatman to explore with the council the possibility of publishing a summary of CapEx-funded works and their impact.

7. PA System / Match-Day Announcer

Paul Gallagher said he had emailed John Bird the previous week to raise that the match-day commentary has been difficult to hear from the Corner Stand throughout the season so far, and that supporters at the Norman Rimmington South Stand and West Stand had also mentioned it. Dominic Wood said he had also raised the issue with Jon Flatman after the recent Blackpool game, describing the sound as more muffled.

Jon Flatman confirmed the equipment and setup are unchanged; the difference is a new operator following Jason's departure. He said the club does not attribute blame to the individual, who has stepped in and done a good job, and that work is under way to establish whether the issue is with the equipment or technique.

Martin Wilson asked whether the announcer could be asked to slow down, which Jon Flatman agreed to raise. Phil Hall noted that feedback he received after Saturday's game was that sound quality had significantly improved compared with earlier fixtures, and urged patience while the new operator settles in; Jon Flatman, seated in the West Stand, agreed the improvement was noticeable from where he sat, but said the club would continue to monitor the situation.

Outcome: Acknowledged; club investigating and monitoring, with early signs of improvement.

8. 2027 — 30th Anniversary of Promotion to the Premiership

Steve reported that he, Phil Hall, Peter Harrison and Paul Gallagher had met with Darren Hayes from the club the previous week to discuss plans for the 30th anniversary of promotion to the Premiership.

Peter Harrison summarised the discussion: the club is considering marking the anniversary around the home game against Stockport on 24 April 2027, including a commemorative matchday programme and inviting former players from the promotion squad. Nicky Eaden has already contacted most of the former squad, the majority of whom are keen to attend; two players — believed to be Matty Appleby and Clint Marcelle — have not yet been reached.

A separate evening event is also planned for the same day at the Metrodome, described as an informal gathering ("pies and a pint") rather than a formal dinner, to make it accessible to a wide number of supporters given the venue's capacity. The plan includes inviting former players, a screening of the Daydream Believers film, and live interviews, with Jason proposed to host. Paul Gallagher confirmed he had spoken to Liam Dyson, who was involved in the original Daydream Believers film and is happy to get involved

and support use of the footage. Phil Hall confirmed he had also spoken to Matt Goodwin who was heavily involved in the Daydream Believers Film and is happy to get involved.

Steve confirmed the four attendees who met with Darren will form a working group, alongside other supporter organisations, to generate further ideas and feed them into the planning group Darren has started with Nicky Eaden.

Jon Flatman asked that the working group keep its ambitions realistic and manageable, noting it would be an unreasonable burden to place an entire day's events solely on Darren, who has already asked the group for support.

Dominic Wood suggested Liam Dyson, given his enthusiasm and local standing, be considered for one of the FAB's two vacant positions, which have been on hold pending resolution of an unrelated matter (referred to as "the IFR issue"). Steve said his personal view is that, if a suitable candidate is keen to join, the group should proceed to fill the vacancies. Paul Gallagher noted Liam Dyson would likely be present at an upcoming Supporters Trust meeting and could be approached there.

Actions:

- Working group (Steve, Phil Hall, Peter Harrison, Paul Gallagher) to continue gathering ideas and feed them into the club's planning group.
- Paul Gallagher to gauge Liam Dyson's interest in one of the two vacant FAB positions.

9. Car Parking

Paul Gallagher relayed feedback from a supporter, Sean, who had previously contacted John Bird directly. The issues raised were: cars queuing on Grove Street because a van previously stationed to block through-traffic is no longer in place; inconsistent communication to supporters queuing in cars about when they will be released, causing frustration; and a suggestion that retractable bollards be fitted to the large vehicle gates so they can be opened for pedestrian egress without releasing cars.

John Bird confirmed he had spoken to Sean by phone after the first home game affected (either the Lincoln or Wigan fixture), where pedestrians were funnelled to a single gate. He explained a review of road closures around the ground is under way between the club and the council, as part of a wider review of hostile vehicle mitigation measures being carried out at grounds generally, which may result in changes; the current arrangement should not be changed in the meantime as it may need to change again shortly.

Dominic Wood, speaking from a traffic and safety management perspective, clarified that gate operation is managed by the club's safety team rather than the traffic management contractor, and that there have been 17 reported incidents this season of vehicles being moved or parked within the sterile zone ahead of road closures being lifted, in an attempt to leave more quickly. He explained the standard hold period (around 20 minutes) exists to protect pedestrians walking on the road, and acknowledged the frustration this causes, including for himself as a hospitality car park user.

Paul Gallagher noted that, on a positive note, Sean had been complimentary about the staff managing the car park. Steve also noted that John Bird had been praised for the speed of his response to earlier car park queries following the Bromley game and another fixture.

A separate query was raised about reported damage to a car park wall some years ago. John Bird confirmed the wall had been repaired a number of years ago and that he had checked it again that day; it remains intact. He suggested the query may relate to a missing section of metal fencing between pillars at the bottom of the car park, rather than the wall itself.

Actions:

- No changes to current car park exit arrangements pending the outcome of the club and council's road closure review.
- John Bird to continue as the main point of contact for car park queries raised by supporters.

10. Lighting Design Plans — Transparency Request

Steve raised a query from a supporter asking, out of personal interest rather than complaint, whether the plans for the new lighting design could be shared. Jon Flatman said his instinct was that sharing detailed designs was a step too far and risked setting a precedent for similar requests regarding other confidential business information, though he was open to the club offering a short informal walkthrough if the supporter wished to visit. Peter Harrison noted there may also be intellectual property right considerations between the club and the lighting designer. Steve agreed the club's position was reasonable in this instance, noting the question had been asked in good faith.

Outcome: Detailed plans will not be shared; an informal walkthrough could be offered if requested directly.

11. Fan Zone

Steve asked about the status of the fan zone shown on a map on the club website, given fan zone references had already been removed from the club's customer charter, and whether this was simply an outstanding website update. John Bird confirmed the fan zone paragraph has been removed from planning documents, but the club has not yet done the work needed to assess the cost and potential return of reinstating a fan zone. John Bird confirmed the only remaining reference is a small labelled area on an access map within the customer charter, which he will arrange to have removed to avoid confusion, given there are no imminent plans for a fan zone.

Dominic Wood proposed an alternative concept: relocating turnstiles to the stairs and using the covered lower concourse at the East Stand (which already has television screens and access to food and drink) as a fan zone. Jon Flatman raised a safety consideration around emergency egress needing to lead into a clear area, but agreed the idea was worth exploring further, noting existing vomitories (concourse exit points) might provide sufficient flow capacity. John Bird agreed it would be useful for Dominic Wood to walk the space with him to demonstrate the idea in person.

Actions:

- John Bird to remove the outdated fan zone reference from the customer charter map.
- Dominic Wood and John Bird to walk through the lower East Stand concourse concept together, subject to a safety review.

12. Away / Travel Kit

Steve asked whether the club's retail partner, Fanatics, has plans to stock the away travel kit. Jon Flatman confirmed Fanatics currently has no plans to do so, as stocking decisions are theirs to make commercially, based on anticipated demand; the club does not have direct input into these decisions but will raise the question with them. He noted Fanatics now has three years of sales data to inform such decisions.

Martin Wilson sought clarification on terminology; Jon Flatman confirmed the item in question is officially referred to as "travel gear" rather than an away training kit. Steve also asked whether a third kit exists; Jon Flatman confirmed one does, but declined to give further details ahead of its announcement.

Outcome: No current stocking plans; club to raise supporter demand with Fanatics.

Update: Fanatics will stock the grey travel kit and it is expected in the club shop imminently.

Any Other Business

AuraCast: Phil Hall confirmed a session with Craig from Ampetronic has been arranged for Thursday 17 September, provisionally at 2pm, timed to work around Jon Flatman's Health and Safety quarterly review that morning. Phil Hall to confirm details and copy John Bird in.

Headset returns: Martin Wilson reported he had been unable to return his headset after leaving Saturday's game early, as the ticket office was unstaffed. John Bird confirmed reception is now staffed for around 20 minutes after the final whistle, and that headsets can otherwise be left at the club shop. Martin Wilson asked for a charged headset to be available for the Leicester fixture, and will return his current one at that time.

FAB contact details: John Bird confirmed he has reset the relevant passwords and will forward access details to Steve, offering to assist him in person if needed. Once complete, John Bird will send an email to supporters outlining FAB members' contact details.

Meeting frequency: John Bird raised whether the FAB should continue meeting monthly or move to a less frequent schedule. Views were mixed: Robin Harris favoured moving to roughly two-monthly, noting other clubs' FABs typically meet every two to three months and that recurring items (such as car parking) could be batched rather than revisited every month; Martin Wilson, Phil Hall, Paul Gallagher and Peter Harrison were flexible between six weeks and two months; Jon Flatman favoured two-monthly, citing the demands of balancing this with matchday commitments; Dominic Wood argued strongly for keeping meetings monthly, citing concern about losing momentum and wanting to see tangible progress on the items discussed. The group agreed a compromise of six-weekly meetings, with Steve to circulate dates for the next five to six meetings in advance. It was agreed Thursdays are generally preferable to avoid clashing with Tuesday fixtures, and that Jon Flatman may send John Bird as a deputy when unavailable.

Plymouth Argyle ticket pricing: Martin Wilson raised continuing concern over Plymouth Argyle's pricing structure, under which wheelchair user tickets are cheaper than ambulant disabled tickets. John Bird explained this reflects Plymouth's ground layout, where wheelchair spaces have restricted sightlines due to the position of digital advertising boards, and that Plymouth had previously responded to a query on this raised via Level Playing Field. Martin Wilson said he remained unhappy with the pricing structure but understood the explanation.

Pre-match walkout music: Peter Harrison relayed feedback from supporters around him in the West Stand that the music before the Bromley game had been considered flat, with a request for more upbeat music, citing Sheffield Steelers ice hockey as an example of effective use of music to energise a crowd. Robin Harris, a regular Sheffield Steelers attendee, agreed the Bromley playlist had been subdued but felt Saturday's selection was a marked improvement — more upbeat and contributing to a better atmosphere — and that supporters around him had commented on the improvement unprompted. Peter Harrison confirmed that supporters around him also noted a vast improvement on Saturday. Steve noted strong personal support for retaining "Time Rider" as the pre-match anthem, which holds personal significance to him.

Female sanitary products (follow-up): Claire Calton, having joined the meeting later, asked whether the club was still supplying sanitary products in the toilets, having noticed none available over the last two games despite this being discussed previously (see Agenda Item 2). Jon Flatman confirmed the club remains committed to this and is looking into whether maintenance had stopped supply for an operational reason.

Actions Log

Action	Owner	Deadline
Add a note to future minutes showing approval and publication dates	John Bird	Ongoing, from next set of minutes
Finalise and confirm supply arrangements for sanitary products in toilets	Jon Flatman / maintenance team	Completed
Take scoreboard funding question to the Supporters Trust and circulate suggestions	Paul Gallagher	Before next meeting

Action	Owner	Deadline
Approach AV industry contacts for comparative scoreboard quotes	Peter Harrison	Not specified
Arrange a separate meeting to discuss funding ideas for the scoreboard and Academy	Steve / group	Not specified
Produce a shortlist of five or six Academy funding opportunities with indicative costs	Jon Flatman	Not specified
Provide update once Ozone / Redfern's Bar plans are finalised	Jon Flatman	Not specified
Complete installation of additional lighting around West Stand and East Stand	Club	Not specified
Explore publishing a summary of CapEx-funded works and their impact	Jon Flatman	Not specified
Investigate and continue monitoring PA/commentary audio quality	Jon Flatman	Ongoing
Continue working group activity for 30th anniversary celebrations	Steve, Phil Hall, Peter Harrison, Paul Gallagher	Ongoing, ahead of 24 April 2027
Gauge Liam Dyson's interest in a vacant FAB position	Paul Gallagher	Not specified
Remove outdated fan zone reference from customer charter map	John Bird	Not specified
Walk through lower East Stand concourse fan zone concept	Dominic Wood / John Bird	Not specified
Raise supporter demand for away/travel kit with Fanatics	Jon Flatman	Completed
Confirm AuraCast session details and circulate to John Bird	Phil Hall	Completed
Ensure a charged headset is available	John Bird	Completed
Forward FAB email access details to Steve; send FAB contact details to supporters	John Bird	Completed
Circulate next five to six meeting dates on a six-weekly cycle	Steve Brain	Not specified

Meeting minutes approved: Monday 14th September

Meeting minutes published: Monday 14th September